

PAUSE. PIVOT. POINT.

*A Framework for Reaching
the Students Your School
Almost Lost*

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The Dream Shake is the Framework.

PAUSE

*The hesitation.
Reaction avoided.*

PIVOT

*The spin move.
Action taken.*

POINT

*The basket.
The lesson beneath.*

*Hakeem didn't react. He read. He moved. He scored.
That's what great educators do every single day.*

You know this student.

The one who's been written off.

Cycled through.

Given up on before they ever walked into your
room.

You chose this work anyway.

But surviving the day isn't the same as
reaching them.

THE HIGHWAY.

A story about moving instead of talking.



**You can't say anything crazier.
You have to move differently.**

— Shane Nelson, on his grandfather

Putnam Heights Academy

Oklahoma City Public Schools • Alternative Behavioral School

150

Students
Grades 5-12

27

Years in
Public Education

100%

Dignity
First Policy

"I did not want stigma to speak first. I wanted dignity to speak first."

The Motto

I have value.

My life has a purpose.

I will succeed.

These words are not decoration. They are a sequence.

The Pause. Pivot. Point. Framework

PAUSE

Reaction avoided.

The space between what a student does and what you do next. It is not silence. It is strategy.

PIVOT

Action taken.

A deliberate redirection that bypasses the ego and opens a door. Not appeasement — the opposite of it.

POINT

The lesson beneath.

What the moment was actually about. The teaching that happens when everything else is out of the way.

PAUSE

Reaction avoided.

What Is the Pause?

A student slams a book down. Walks out. Says something disrespectful.

Your nervous system wants to react. That is biology.

The Pause is the moment between stimulus and response where you choose what kind of educator you are going to be right now.

It is not weakness. It is the first move.

The Cost of Reacting Without Pausing

- The student wins the moment — and they know it.
- The audience (every other kid in the room) watches you lose the room.
- You've confirmed that emotion, not strategy, runs the class.
- You've spent the next 20 minutes managing the aftermath instead of teaching.
- You may never recover their trust.

Pause in Practice

WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE

- Lower your voice instead of raising it
- Take a physical step back
- Redirect attention to the room before re-engaging the student
- Buy yourself 10 seconds before you say anything

WHAT IT IS NOT

- Backing down
- Ignoring the behavior
- Letting it go
- Appeasement

The Pause is a skill. It gets better with practice — and it is never the final move.



**You don't have to win the fight.
You just have to make them uncertain
whether winning is worth it.**

— *Shane Nelson · Pause. Pivot. Point.*

PIVOT

Action taken.

What Is the Pivot?

The Pivot is the deliberate move you make after the Pause.

It is not a reaction. It is a choice.

The Pivot redirects without triggering the student's ego defense system. It reads the student, finds a door that's open, and walks through it — instead of kicking down the one that's locked.

Hakeem didn't charge at the defender. He read the defender and moved where there was space.

Reading the Student

*Every student is a banana at a different stage of ripeness.
Your job is not to wish they were a different banana.
Your job is to handle the one in front of you.*

The Redirect in Action:

A student acting out in the office. Instead of confronting the behavior head-on, Shane called him out for "talking to 3 girls today." The student got embarrassed. Inflated. Then sat down.

No lecture. No power struggle. No anger. The behavior redirected without ever triggering the student's ego defense.

That is the Pivot.

GRADUATION MORNING.

Pause. Pivot. Point. In one morning.



**I took myself out of the
equation on purpose.**

— *Shane Nelson, on Gabriel*

The Pivot Is NOT Appeasement

APPEASEMENT	THE PIVOT
Making deals to end conflict	Moving with intention to teach through conflict
Student wins, educator loses	Neither wins — learning wins
Buys silence with surrender	Buys engagement with strategy
Sends the message: you are in charge	Sends the message: I see you and I'm still here
Feels easier in the moment — costs more later	Harder in the moment — pays more later

A Word About PT.

PT = Poop Teaching.

The hardest job in the world:
being an amazing teacher.

The easiest job in the world:
being a PT.

Come in. Don't give the kids anything meaningful.
Make sure they're occupied so they won't eat your lunch.

That's it. That's PT.

Appeasement Is Not a Procedure

When a teacher appeases a student, what they are actually saying is:

"I don't have a procedure or a process — and this student doesn't understand who I am as a person. So I'm going to allow it because I don't have the foundation to push back."

Appeasement is an admission. Once someone else takes the ring, the door opens — and some of what walks through that door is the antithesis of learning.

You cannot afford to appease.

You are not there to make deals.

You are there to feed them their future.



**De-escalation is not weakness.
It is the hardest move in the room.**

— *Shane Nelson · Pause. Pivot. Point.*

POINT

The lesson beneath.

What Is the Point?

The Point is what the moment was **actually** about.

Not the behavior you redirected. Not the conflict you navigated.

The lesson that only became possible **because you paused and pivoted**.

The Point is where the child receives something they can carry out of your room.



**The point of the lesson
is never the lesson.**

**The point of the lesson
is the child.**

— *Shane Nelson · Pause. Pivot. Point.*

Build Your Own Pause. Pivot. Point.

Pair up with a friend or a stranger. You'll have about 7 minutes.

01

Pick one small, real situation you deal with often — phones out during instructions, three kids crammed in one bathroom stall, a student who won't sit down.

02

Write your own Event, Pause, Pivot, and Point. This isn't a group answer — everyone fills in their own.

03

Trade with your partner. Say out loud what you'd actually pivot to. That's the practice.

One Example, Filled In

EVENT	THE PAUSE <i>What most people do — “It’s not about me!”</i>	THE PIVOT <i>What I will do</i>	THE POINT <i>My goal — not theirs</i>
Phones out during instructions	“Put it away!” — raised voice, instant power struggle.	Name what I see. Redirect to the task, not the phone.	Get them back on task — not prove who’s in charge.

Now build one of your own — on paper, with your partner.

Compliment Effort. Not Result.

SAY THIS

"I love the effort you made on this."

"I love that I saw you spend 40 straight minutes nose-deep in that test."

"I love your growth."

NOT THIS

"Great job getting 100."

"I'm glad you got the right answer."

"You achieved perfection."

What we compliment, we grow. What we grow, we keep.

Small Wins Are the Whole Game

→ A kid at the bus stop at 6:30 AM with no one making them go

→ Two students working as partners without being told to

→ A hand raised instead of a desk flipped

→ Eye contact. A "yes sir." A question asked

→ Showing up. Just showing up.

The Urgency of Their Time

Students are only with you for a limited time each day. 45 minutes. Maybe 90.

It may feel like an eternity. But they have 24 hours in their day.

Their friends have them for hours.

Their coach has them.

The outside world has them.

How efficient do you have to be to overcome their friends' influence?

How amazing do you have to be to outpace that long conversation they had with their coach?

That is the level of commitment required.

The Nelson Code: Four Tenets of Great Teaching

SEE CLEARLY

See the invisible. Honor the story. Build with meaning. Start with the child in front of you, not the label attached to them.

MOVE PEOPLE

Great educators don't manage classrooms. They move people. Connection before correction. Every time.

GO HARD

Half-effort is not an option when the forgotten ones are counting on the best version of you. The work demands all of you.

STAND FIRM

Your identity as an educator cannot be negotiated away. Culture is not a mood. Dignity is a strategy. Hold the line.

"See the Invisible. Honor the Story."

What are they carrying that you haven't asked about?

*NOT — How are your grades?
HOW — How are you?*

*They didn't choose their
trauma.
You get to choose how you
respond to it.*

*The gaps between adults
are where forgotten students
fall through.*

The Three-Line Culture Diagnostic

Ask these three questions about your school or classroom:

01

When is the last time dignity spoke first in a difficult moment — before consequences, before policy, before frustration?

02

Where are the gaps between adults in your building — and are forgotten students falling through them?

03

Are the students who need the most receiving the best you have — or the version left over after everything else?



**I did not want stigma to speak first.
I wanted dignity to speak first.**

— Shane Nelson • Putnam Heights Academy

You leave with this Monday.

PAUSE

Before you respond to a hard moment — take one breath. Lower your voice instead of raising it. Buy yourself 10 seconds.

PIVOT

Choose a door that's open. Find the thing they care about. Redirect without triggering the ego. This is the skill.

POINT

After the storm, name what happened. Give them something to hold. Compliment the effort. Make the moment mean something.

Apply it once this week. Tell a colleague. Watch what changes.

THE CAFETERIA.

A small win, and an open ending.



**He came to summer school.
He didn't finish. And I'm still there.**

— Shane Nelson, on Axzavier

The Forgotten Ones.

They are quiet. They blend in.
They have learned to survive without asking for much.
They have been mislabeled, underestimated, or never truly seen.

*The forgotten ones you pour into every day deserve the best
version of you
— not the version that showed up after everyone else already
took their share.*

Some of them are in your building right now.



**The greater the struggle,
the more opportunity you have to
rise.**

— *Shane Nelson · Pause. Pivot. Point.*

The Book

PAUSE. PIVOT. POINT.

SHANE NELSON

Pause. Pivot. Point.

Coming Soon · itsanelson.com

This book is for every educator who has ever stood in a hard moment and wondered if what they did mattered.

It did. It does. This framework is the proof.

Part practitioner's guide, part story collection — built from 27 years of real classrooms and real kids.



**We don't always change a trajectory.
We enrich it.**

— Shane Nelson

They need to hear it from you.

I have value.

My life has a purpose.

I will succeed.

That is the Point.

PAUSE. PIVOT. POINT.

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